

Session 12: Joseph the Wise Deliverer of Egypt

Key Takeaways

- Yoseph is lifted out of the pit, shaved, and given a whole new set of garments. In the Bible, shaving often marks a transition between two phases of life or states of being.
- The doubling in Pharaoh's dream points to one reality confirmed by God, giving us further insight into the pattern of doubling in the Yoseph story as a whole.
- Yoseph is presented as a new Noah, with Pharaoh's house as the ark where others will find shelter and provision.

Yoseph Elevated To Become Wise Deliverer of Egypt

Genesis 41:1-16

Dreams and Their Interpretation

41:1-8

Pharaoh's Two Dreams

- 7 good cows eaten by 7 bad cows
- 7 good sheaves swallowed by 7 bad sheaves
- Pharaoh's spirit is troubled, no interpreter for the dreams

41:9-13

The Cup-Bearer Captain Tells About Yoseph

- A story of two dreams
- Young Hebrew boy

41:14-16

Yoseph Brought to Pharaoh

- Yoseph lifted out of the pit and given new garments
- Only Elohim can interpret dreams

Genesis 41:17-36

Interpretation of Pharaoh's Dreams and a Plan

41:17-24

Pharaoh Recounts His Two Dreams

- 7 good cows eaten by 7 bad cows
- 7 good sheaves swallowed by 7 bad sheaves

41:25-32

- The two dreams are one in meaning
- 7 good cows/sheaves are 7 years of abundance
- 7 bad cows/sheaves are 7 years of famine
- Elohim has doubled the dreams because he is about to do it

41:33-36

- Appoint a wise man to divide the land into five
- Pharaoh should store up food during 7 years of abundance
- The land won't be cut off during the 7 years of famine

Genesis 41:37-57

Yoseph's Plan Is Realized and the Dreams Come to Pass

41:37-46

- Pharaoh recognizes Yoseph as a wise man with the Spirit of Elohim
- Yoseph elevated to second-place ruler over Egypt and given royal garments
- Yoseph rides the chariot, and Egypt kneels before him

41:47-52

- Pharaoh gives Yoseph an Egyptian name and provides him an Egyptian wife
- Yoseph stores up food during the 7 years of abundance
- Yoseph's wife has two sons who are named

41:53-57

- The 7 years of abundance come to an end
- The 7 years of famine begin
- The famine is strong over all the land, the people cry out for bread

Genesis 41:1-57. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

This large, culminating chapter brings many of the themes in Genesis 37-41 to a partial climax. It consists of three large parts, arranged in a large symmetry, though there are many interconnections between each of the parts.

- Part 1 (Gen. 41:1-16) introduces Pharaoh's two dreams about the seven cows and sheaves, interpreted by Yoseph, who is elevated up out of the pit and given new clothes.
- Part 2 (Gen. 41:17-36) focuses on the dialogue between Yoseph and Pharaoh about the two dreams about seven cows/sheaves and how they point to seven years of abundance and famine.
- Part 3 (Gen. 41:37-57) recounts Yoseph's second elevation and second set of new garments, marking him as the second-in-command over all Egypt who will prepare for the seven years of abundance and famine.

¹ And it came about after **two years** of days,
that Phar'oh **had a dream**,
and look: he was standing by the river,
² and look: from the river there came up **seven cows**,
beautiful to see, and fat of flesh,
and they grazed in the marshes,
³ and look: **seven other cows** came up after them,
bad to see, and skinny of flesh,
and they stood beside the cows on the shore of the river,
⁴ and the cows that were bad to see and thin of flesh,
they ate the **seven cows** that were beautiful to see and fat.

And Phar'oh woke up.

⁵ And he fell asleep **and dreamed a second time**,
and look: **seven ears of grain** came up on one stalk, fat and good,
⁶ and look: **seven ears of grain**, thin and burned by hot east wind, sprouted after them,
⁷ and the ears of grain that were thin swallowed the **seven ears** that were fat and full.

And Phar'oh woke up, and look: it was **a dream**.

⁸ And it came about in the morning that his spirit was agitated,
and he sent and he called to all the sorcerers of Egypt and all its wise ones,
and Phar'oh recounted to them **his dream**,
but there was for Phar'oh **no interpreter** for it.

⁹ And the captain of the cup-bearers spoke to Phar'oh, saying,
"I am, today, about to **make remembrance** of my sins."
¹⁰ Phar'oh was angry with his servants,
and he gave me into the prison,
the house of the captain of the butchers,
me, and the captain of the bakers;

11 and we dreamed a dream in one night, I and he,
 each according to the interpretation of his dream, we dreamed,
 12 and there with us was a young man, a Hebrew servant of the captain of the butchers,
 and we recounted to him our dreams,
 each according to his dream, he interpreted.
 13 And just as he interpreted for us, so it came about.
 He returned me to my post, and he hung him.

14 And Phar'oh sent and he called Yoseph,
 and he made him run out of the pit,
 and he was shaved and he changed his clothes,
 and he came to Phar'oh.

15 And Phar'oh said to Yoseph,
 "I dreamed a dream,
 but there is no interpreter of it.
 I have heard about you,
 saying that you can hear a dream to interpret it."

16 And Yoseph answered Phar'oh, saying,
 "Not really me!
 Elohim can attest to the peace of Phar'oh."

Genesis 41:1-16. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Pharaoh's Dreams and His Officials' Dreams

There is a clear similarity between Pharaoh's dreams and those of the officials he imprisoned in the previous chapter. This sets up an analogy between the two, so their dreams and following fulfillment create expectation in the reader that all four dreams will follow a similar course.

Genesis 40	Genesis 41
Gen. 40:5 The cupbearer and baker of Pharaoh each have a dream: "The two of them dreamed a dream on one night, each according to the meaning (פִּתְרוֹן) of his dream"	Gen. 41:1-8 Pharaoh has two dreams in one night: "And it came about in the morning ..."
Gen. 40:6 As a result, "they were vexed (זָעַזְעוּ)"	Gen. 41:8 As a result, his breath was "flustered"
Comparing Genesis 40 and 41. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Genesis 40	Genesis 41
	(פעם)
Gen. 40:8 “There was not an interpreter (פֶּתֶר אֵין) of it”	Gen. 41:8 After consulting his sorcerers, “there was no interpreter (אֵין פֹּתֵר) of them”
Gen. 40:10 Cupbearer’s dream: “On a vine were three tendrils, and as it blossomed, a flower came up (עָלָה) and bloomed a cluster of grapes”	Gen. 41:5-7 Second dream: “Seven grain-ears came up (עָלָה) in one stalk, fat and good ...”
Gen. 40:17 Baker’s dream: “Three baskets of cake ... and the top basket had all food (מֵאֵכֶל) for Pharaoh ...”	Gen. 41:1-4 First dream: “Seven cows came up (עָלָה), beautiful of appearance (מְרֵאָה) ... and seven other came up (עָלָה) and ate (אָכַל) the seven beautiful of appearance cows”
Gen. 40:1 The cupbearer and baker are imprisoned because “they sinned (חָטְאוּ) against Pharaoh”	Gen. 41:9 The cupbearer reminds Pharaoh of “my sins” (חַטֹּאתַי)
Gen. 40:12, 18 Yoseph interprets: “This is its interpretation” (זֶה פִּתְרוֹנוֹ)	Gen. 41:28 Yoseph interprets: “This is the matter (הוּא הַדְּבָר) which I speak to Pharaoh: What God is about to do, he has shown to Pharaoh.”
Gen. 40:8 “Don’t interpretations belong to God?”	Gen. 41:16 “Apart from me! God will give an answer to the wellbeing of Pharaoh”
Comparing Genesis 40 and 41. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

17 And Phar’oh spoke to Yoseph ,

“In **my dream** , look I was standing on the shore of the river,

18 and look, from the river came up **seven cows**, fat of flesh and beautiful of form, and they grazed in the marshes.

19 And look, **seven other cows** came up after them, impoverished, very **bad** of form, and empty of flesh;

I had not seen anything so **bad** as these in all the land.

20 And the cows, the empty and **bad** ones, they ate the **seven cows**, the first fat ones,

21 and they went into their innards,

but it wasn’t known that they went into their innards, as their appearance was just as **bad** as in the beginning.

And then I woke up.

22 And I saw in **my dream** ,
and look: **seven ears of grain** coming up from one stalk, full and **good** .
23 And look: **seven hardened ears of grain**, thin and shriveled by the east wind, sprouting after them,
24 and the ears of grain, the thin ones, swallowed up the **seven ears of grain**, the **good** ones.

And I spoke to the sorcerers ,
but there was no one to tell it to me.

25 **And Yoseph said to Phar'oh** ,
“ **The dream** of Phar'oh, it is one.
What Elohim is about to do, **he has told** to Phar'oh .
26 **The seven good cows, they are seven years**,
and **the seven good ears of grain, they are seven years**.

It is one dream .
27 And the thin and **bad** cows that came up after them,
they are **seven years**,
and the **seven** ears of grain, the empty ones, shriveled by the east wind,
they are **seven years** of **famine** .
28 This is **the word that I have spoken** to Phar'oh,
what Elohim is about to do, **he has shown** it to Phar'oh .

29 Look, **seven** years are coming,
of great **fullness** in all the land of Egypt.
30 And there will arise **seven** years of **famine** after them,
and all the **fullness** in the land of Egypt will be forgotten,
and the **famine** will bring an end to the land,
31 and the **fullness** of the land will not be known,
because of that **famine** , and afterwards,
because it will be very heavy.
32 And about **the doubling** of **the dream** of Pharaoh, two times,
indeed **the spoken-word** is firmly established by Elohim,
and Elohim is just about to do it.

33 And now, let Phar'oh see to a man, an understanding and wise one,
and he should set him over the land of Egypt.

34 **Phar'oh should do it**,
and he should **appoint appointees over the land**,
and divide the land of Egypt into five in the **seven years of fullness** .
35 And they should gather all the food of these coming **good** years,

and they should store grain under the hand of Phar'oh,
food in the **cities** that they should guard.

36 And the food can be **appointed for the land**,
for the **seven years** of the **famine** that will be in the land of Egypt,
so the land won't be cut off by the **famine**."

Genesis 41:17-36. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

37 And the word was **good** in the eyes of Phar'oh
and in the eyes of all his servants;

38 and Phar'oh said to his servants,
"Is there another man like this,
who has **the spirit of Elohim in him**?!"

39 And Phar'oh said to Yoseph,
"Following from the fact that **Elohim made all this known to you**,
there is no one as **understanding and wise** as you!

40 **You yourself** will be **over my house**,
and upon your mouth, all my people will kiss.
Only in the throne will I be greater than you."

41 And Phar'oh said to Yoseph,
"Look, **I have made you to be over all the land of Egypt**."

42 And Phar'oh removed his ring from **upon his hand**,
and he gave it **upon the hand** of Yoseph,
and he clothed him in garments of linen,
and he set a necklace of gold **upon his neck**.

43 And he made him ride in the second chariot which belonged to him,
and he called out before him,
"Kneel!"
And so **he made him to be over all the land of Egypt**.

44 And Phar'oh said to Yoseph,
"**I myself** am Phar'oh,
and **aside from you, no man will lift his hand or his foot**, in **all the land of Egypt**."

Genesis 41:37-44. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

45 And **Phar'oh called the name of Yoseph**,
"Tsaph'nath-Pa'ne'akh" (Egyptian = "The Deity Said, 'He Will Live!'")
and he gave to him **Asenath, daughter of Potiphra, the priest of 'On**, as a wife,
and Yoseph went out over the land of Egypt.

46 Now, Yoseph was **a son of thirty years** when he stood before Phar'oh king of Egypt,
and Yoseph went out from before Phar'oh,
and he passed **through all the land of Egypt**.

47 And the land produced for **the seven years of fullness**, many handfuls,

48 and he gathered all **the food** of the years which were in the land of Egypt,
and he put **the food** into cities,
food of the fields of the city that were around it,
he put into its midst.

49 And Yoseph stored up **grain** like the sand of the sea,
it was very abundant,
to the degree that one stopped counting, because it was beyond numbering.

50 Now, for Yoseph were born two **sons**, before **the year of famine** came,
whom **Asenath, the daughter of Potiphra, priest of 'On**, she bore for him.

51 And **Yoseph called the name** of the **firstborn**,
"**Menasheh (מנשה)**,"
because Elohim has made me forget (נשח) all my toil and all the house of my father."

52 And **the name** of the **second**, **he called**,
"**Ephrayim (אפרים)**,"
because Elohim has made me fruitful (פרי) in the land of my oppression."

Genesis 41:45-52. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

53 And so were **finished** the **seven years of fullness**
that were **in the land of Egypt**,

54 and so **began** the **seven years** of the coming **famine**,
just as **Yoseph** had said.

And the famine was in all the lands,
but in **all the land of Egypt** there was **bread**.

55 And there was **famine in all the land of Egypt**,
and the people cried out to Phar'oh for **bread**,
and Phar'oh said to all of Egypt,
"Go to **Yoseph**,

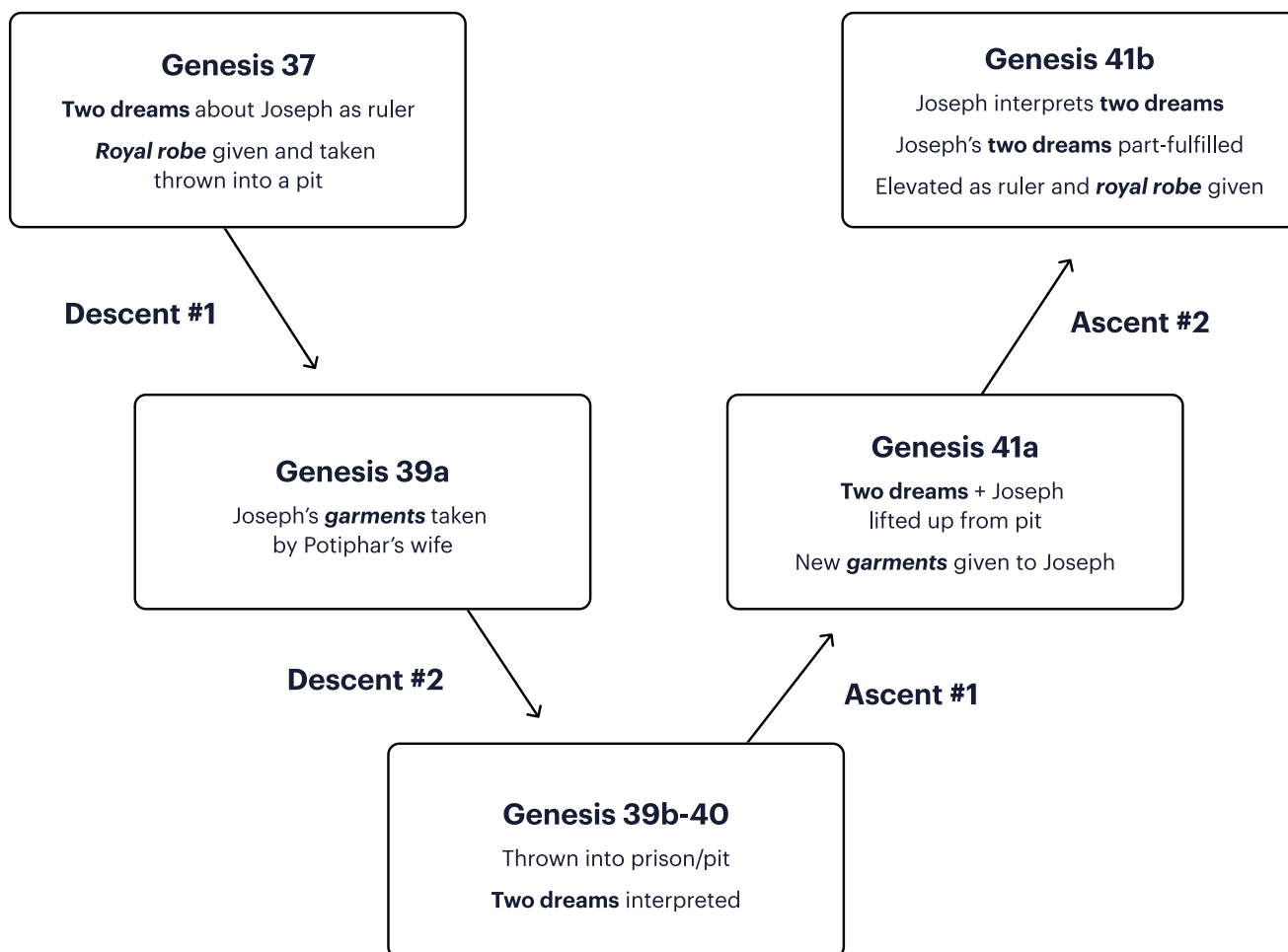
he will tell you what to do!"

⁵⁶ And the **famine** was upon **all** **the face of Egypt**,
and **Yoseph** opened up everything that was in them,
and he sold **grain to Egypt**,
and the **famine** was strong **in the land of Egypt**,
⁵⁷ and **all the land** was coming **to Egypt** to buy **grain** from **Yoseph**,
because **the famine was strong in all the land**.

Genesis 41:53-57. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

The Descent and Exaltation of Yoseph

In Genesis 41, the narrative arc that began in chapter 37 comes full circle. Yoseph's two dreams that led to his double descent (from a pit into Egypt, from a house into a prison) bring us to a pivot where two more dreams become the key to his ascent. It is then Pharaoh's two dreams that require Yoseph's expertise, and so he is exalted to interpret the dreams and is placed in the elevated role of second-in-command over Egypt.



The Role of the Garment in the Joseph Story. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Dreams of Creation and De-Creation

Pharaoh's dreams are packed with vocabulary from [Genesis 1-6](#) that sets up analogies between the years of abundance/famine and the story of creation and de-creation.

Pharaoh's Dreams in Genesis 41	Creation and De-creation in Genesis 1-6
7 cows (פרה) that are fat (בריאת) and beautiful of appearance (יפות מראה) and 7 sheaves that are fat (בריאה) and good (טוב)	7 days of creation (ברא) that result in trees with fruit (פרי) that are good of appearance (טוב מראה)
<i>Pharaoh's Dreams as Decreation.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Pharaoh's Dreams in Genesis 41	Creation and De-creation in Genesis 1-6
7 cows (פרה) that are bad (רע) of appearance (מראה), that eat (אכל) the fat cows, ending the time of abundance 7 sheaves that are thin and burned by hot wind (קדים) rise up to swallow (בלע) the good sheaves	The fruit (פרי) on the tree of knowing good (טוב) and bad (רע) is eaten (אכל), resulting in exile and the end of abundance The fruit (פרי) on the tree of knowing good (טוב) and bad (רע) is swallowed, so Yahweh appears in a storm wind (רוח) to the humans
7 bad cows and 7 bad sheaves will consume the abundance of the 7 good cows/sheaves = 7 years of famine that will decrease the 7 years of abundance	Gen. 1:1-2:3, 7:4 Noah waits 7 days for the arrival of the flood that will undo the creation that was made in 7 days.
Gen. 41:21 After the bad cows/sheaves eat the good cows/sheaves, "their appearance was still bad, just as in the beginning (תחלה)."	Gen. 1:1, 7:23-8:1 After the flood waters rise and destroy all life on the land, creation reverts back to wild, wastes, and darkness as in the beginning.
Gen. 41:38 "Can there be found a man like this one, in whom is the Spirit of God (רוח אלהים)?"	Gen. 1:2 "and the spirit of God (רוח אלהים) was hovering over the waters"
<i>Pharaoh's Dreams as Decreation. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

The subtle allusions create a meaningful relationship between the seven days of creation that result in fruit and goodness and the seven years of abundance that Pharaoh has dreamt about. It also creates the inverse analogy between the seven days Noah waits for the flood de-creation and the seven years that threaten to bring an end of all life in the land.

This point leads us to a whole additional set of hyperlinks in [Genesis 41](#) that connect back to the flood story as a whole in [Genesis 6-9](#).

The Selection of a Remnant for a Flood of Famine

Recall that [Genesis 37-39](#) was filled with hyperlinks to [Genesis 1-4](#), where Yoseph was depicted as an appointed ruler whose rule was usurped through the deception and jealous anger of his brothers. Now that Yoseph has been delivered from their evil schemes and exalted once again, the narrator begins to depict him on analogy with Noah during the generation before the flood.

Yoseph describes the 7-year famine as cosmic and cataclysmic in scope:	The flood is described as cosmic and cataclysmic in scope: Gen. 6:17 "Behold, I, even I am bringing the flood of
<i>Being Remembered in the Famine and Flood. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

Gen. 41:31 “ the famine will bring a total end to the land ... for it will be extremely heavy ”	water upon the land, to ruin all flesh in which is the breath of life , from under the skies; everything that is on the land shall perish .” Gen. 7:4 “For after seven more days , I will send rain on the land forty days and forty nights; and I will wipe away from the face of the land every living thing that I have made.”
Yoseph urges Pharaoh to prepare so that “ the land will be not cut off by the famine” (ולא תכרת הארץ ברעב)	Gen. 9:11 God makes a covenant with Noah that “ all flesh will not be cut off (ולא יכרת כל בשר) again by the waters of the flood.”
Gen. 41:56 The famine (רעב) is set on analogy to the waters of the flood: the famine is “ strong ” (חזק), “ over all the face of the land ” (על כל פני הארץ)	Gen. 7:18 the floodwaters were “ mighty ” (גבר) “over the land” (על הארץ) Gen. 7:23 all standing things were blotted out “from upon the face of the land ” (על פני האדמה)
The language of Yoseph storing up food for the great famine: “Let Pharaoh store up grain as food (אכל) in the cities, and it will be food (אכל) appointed for the land”	Gen. 6:21 “And take for yourself from all the food (מאכל) that will be eaten (אכל), and gather together to yourself, and it will be for food (אכלה) for you.
Egypt is the place of refuge under Yoseph’s leadership: Gen. 41:56 he “ opens ” (פתח) the storehouses of grain	The ark is the place of refuge under Noah’s leadership, the door of which is “closed” (סגר) until Noah “ opens ” (פתח) the window.
Gen. 40:14-15 Yoseph asks the the cupbearer “ remember ” (זכר) him “in the pit” (בור) Gen. 40:23 but he does “ not remember ” (לא זכר), “he forgot”	Gen. 8:1 God “ remembered ” (זכר) Noah in the waters
<i>Being Remembered in the Famine and Flood. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

Yoseph as an Exalted Son of Man (i.e., Adam)

The story of Yoseph’s exaltation is described in language reminiscent of the exaltation of humanity in Genesis 1-3. Just as humanity was raised up from the dust and placed in the high mountain garden, so too Yoseph is raised up from the pit to a place of rule over all the land.

All the lands become famine deserts, but in Egypt "there was bread" (Gen. 41:54) because of Yoseph's rule. During the famine, all Egypt comes to Pharaoh, who tells them to go to Yoseph, who sells grain (וישבר) to Egypt and to all the land (Gen. 41:55-57). This feels like an Eden scene where all those outside of the abundant-garden land are now flowing into the land and are met by Yoseph, Pharaoh's second self (see below) and are given bread.

The scene where Pharaoh exalts Yoseph in Genesis 41:39-46 supplies foundational vocabulary and conceptual categories for the exalted son of 'adam role that was forfeited by Adam and Eve in Genesis 2-3 and is recovered in Daniel 7. The portrait of Pharaoh sharing his rule with Yoseph as "second-self" is quite detailed.

- Pharaoh says to Yoseph: "Only on the throne will I be greater than you" (Gen. 41:40); "all my people will kiss upon your mouth" (Gen. 41:40; see Psalm 2).
- Pharaoh shares his "ring from his hand and give it upon the hand of Yoseph, and he clothed him with garments of linen" (Gen. 41:42).
- Pharaoh makes Yoseph "ride on the second chariot" (במרכבת המשנה), and he calls out before Yoseph "Bow!" (אברך), and "he [Pharaoh] set him [Yoseph] over all the land of Egypt" (Gen. 41:43).
- "I am Pharaoh, and apart from you no one will lift his hand or foot in all the land of Egypt" (Gen. 41:44).

Yoseph's name Tzaphenath-Pa'neakh has been given many interpretations.

- Hebrew root derivations: *tsefunot* ("hidden things"), *mofia'* ("he reveals"), *nokhot* ("easily")—"The One Who Easily Reveals Hidden Things." (Targums and *Genesis Rabbah* 90,4)
- Egyptian derivation: (1) *Dd-p3-ntr-ihw.f-aynh*, "God Speaks and He Lives," or "The God Has Said: He Will Live" (Steindorff, Redford).

This scene which equates Yoseph/Pharaoh in terms of shared authority is explored further in the following moments of the Yoseph narrative.

- In Genesis 44:18, Yehudah says to Yoseph, "For as you, as Pharaoh," meaning "You are as Pharaoh in this moment."
- In Genesis 45:8, Yoseph says, "God made me as a father to Pharaoh, and as the lord of all his house, and ruler over all the land of Egypt."
- In Genesis 45:9, Yoseph says, "God has made me as lord for all the land of Egypt, come down (רדה, cf. רדה "rule" in Gen. 1:28).

Reflection Question

How have the previous chapters of the Yoseph story prepared readers to expect the elements of the flood melody that play out in Genesis 41?